

BACK TO THE ROOTS

Three years after being shown the door, the tech-savvy former chief minister Chandrababu Naidu is reverting to party founder N.T. Rama Rao's pro-rural rhetoric in an effort to regain power

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■ By Amarnath K. Menon

He was the poster boy of economic reforms, a geek amongst politicians who believed that poverty alleviation was a trickle-down process and not the other way round. But three years after being shown the door by the voters of the state, the Telugu Desam Party's (TDP) President, N. Chandrababu Naidu may well be rehearsing a different tune.

As the TDP prepares to celebrate the silver jubilee year of its founding, it is harking back to the pro-rural rhetoric of its founder, N.T. Rama Rao, the charismatic former actor who single-handedly ended years of a single party rule in the state. Naidu is Rao's son-in-law, who came to power in a palace coup, by dethroning his father-in-law. But right now, he is busy trying to revive the pro-poor image that the party had in its first 12 years under Rao. "Mixed economy and reforms have not helped in alleviating poverty. While the mixed economy failed to deliver, the reforms only helped in generation of wealth," says Naidu. He was merely reflecting the feelings of many of his partymen, who believed that people living in villages felt left out as the reforms only helped some sections of the society. His new mantra now is: "Reforms and Reality". What he would ideally want is an alternative economic policy to ensure that the fruits of reforms reach the poor and the middle class, who he hopes will vote for his party in the next elections and help him return to power. Though the TDP chief has been harping on this for the last two years, a resolution on the issue was adopted for the first time at the Tirupati convention. "Poverty alleviation does not mean distributing colour television sets like in Tamil Nadu or offering subsidised rice, an exercise to fetch voters," says TDP's

ABOUT TURN: Naidu used the Tirupati meet to propagate a pro-rural image

